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Donating old computers not only reduces e-waste, it can also improve someone's life

Prakash Ballakoor

Advancements in hardware compel one to upgrade one's system every three years or so. When upgrading, what do most people do with their old PCs? Sell it for peanuts. Newer systems can be cheaper by 30 to 50 per cent than systems bought just a couple of years earlier, and can be twice as fast, thus forcing one to sell the old system at less than a fourth of the original price. For example, around two and half years ago, a Pentium IV 2.4 GHz with 512 MB of RAM cost Rs 28,000 to 32,000; now, you can get a Pentium Core Duo or Pentium D 2.8 GHz system for Rs 13,000 to 15,000.

Unhappy with what's being offered for the old system, some find it fit to dump it in the attic, happy in the knowledge that one still owns the system! Others just throw it away.

There's another option we rarely consider: donating computers to people who really need it. We're talking about unprivileged children and youths who would like to work at a computer and get to know what computers are all about, but for lack of money and knowledge, cannot do so. Apart from computer education, there happen to be other areas where organisations would appreciate the donation of a computer. You—like anyone else who has a computer—can help when the time comes to upgrade.

Education First

Cash-strapped NGOs are trying hard to procure systems. As Amita Chaurasia, who works as documentation in-charge at Pratham—a Mumbai-based NGO—says, "Computers excite children's fantasies, and have become a vital tool to attract underprivileged children to education." Echoing this, Imran Pathan (9), a student at Pratham, says, "My computer is really beautiful. I like it a lot. It has lots of games. I am a champion at *Gaddivali*." Imran is talking about games, but that's only the beginning. Having

realised the potential of computers in education, several NGOs such as Pratham (www.pratham.org), United Way of Mumbai (www.unitedwaymumbai.org), ChildLine India (www.childlineindia.org.in), Aarambh, and Hamara Foundation have introduced computers into their educational programs.

Pratham, initiated by UNICEF in 1994, is a community-based grassroots organisation that promotes the education of underprivileged children in India. This NGO, headquartered in Mumbai covers 21 states, with over a million children under its care. Pratham's programmes include "Computer Assisted Learning" in municipal primary schools, government assisted schools, and community centres in slums. Serving over 25,000 children under this programme, the computer provides a perfect tool to Play And Learn. Pratham has a software team that creates maths and language games in local languages. Nabbi Shaikh, 11, says, "My teacher teaches me new things on the computer. The computer has maths games which I learn and teach others. I want to be a computer teacher when I grow up."

IBM has donated four specially-designed computers at the drop-in centre at Baiganwadi in Mumbai in support of the programme. The

Baiganwadi area is close to the biggest "dumping ground" in Mumbai, where thousands of tons of garbage are generated. This is the home of many children. Pratham found it a big challenge to convince the children to bathe, rest, engage in recreation, and learn. They also found it tough to sustain the children's interest in reading and learning activities. With the advent of computers and interactive learning programs, Pratham was amazed how the children were eager to operate the machines. When the computers were installed, the children became adept at using the systems, especially the maths and language games.

Pratham says they have to date had more than 2,500 children availing this facility. Chaurasia says, "The need for computers exists in all our facilities, and there



Imaging Shrikrishna Patkar